

Huge Iceberg Could Threaten Penguins in the South Atlantic Ocean

Scientists are worried that a large iceberg heading toward an island in the South Atlantic Ocean could threaten wildlife there.

Researchers say the iceberg is the largest in the world. It is moving through the South Atlantic toward the island of South Georgia. The island is a British overseas territory that is about 1,400 kilometers east of the Falkland Islands.

Scientists say South Georgia is a main mating ground for wildlife, especially penguins and seals.

The iceberg is officially known as A23a and it measures about 3,500 square kilometers. It has existed since 1986, when it broke off from the Antarctic shelf.

Andrew Meijers is an oceanographer with the British Antarctic Survey. He told the French News Agency (AFP) that scientists have been using satellite imagery to follow the iceberg's movements.

Meijers said observations had shown the iceberg had not broken into smaller pieces like some other so-called "megabergs" that passed through the Southern Ocean. He added that predicting the iceberg's exact path is difficult. But ocean conditions suggest it should reach South Georgia in two to four weeks.

Meijers said he is worried the iceberg will get caught on the underground continental shelf around South Georgia. But he said it is also possible the large ice mass could miss the shelf and continue moving into open waters beyond South Georgia.

If the iceberg does get caught, or stuck, on the shelf, Meijers said it could remain there for months or it could break into pieces. Meijers is concerned that this could harm efforts by penguins and seals on the island to feed and raise their young. Icebergs that have grounded there in the past led to the deaths of young penguins and seals, he said.

Raul Cordero is a mechanical engineer from Chile's University of Santiago. He is also a member of the National Antarctic Research Committee. Cordero told AFP he thinks the iceberg will miss South Georgia.

"The island acts as an obstacle for ocean currents and therefore usually diverts the water long before it reaches the island," he said. "The iceberg is moved by that water flow, so the chances of it hitting are not that high." Cordero added, however, that some iceberg pieces could affect the island.

Soledad Tiranti is a glacier expert who is currently on an Argentinian exploration trip in the Antarctic. She told AFP that icebergs such as A23a "are so deep that before reaching an island or mainland they generally get stuck" on the seabed.

It is currently summer in South Georgia and penguins and seals from the area have been looking for food in the cold Antarctic waters to bring back to their young. Meijers said the animals might have to go around the iceberg if it gets stuck.

He added that if they had to move around it, this would take a lot of their energy, possibly leading to animal deaths. The seal and penguin populations on South Georgia have already been having a "bad season" with cases of bird flu, Meijers said.

Iceberg A23a remained stuck for 30 years before finally breaking free from the Antarctic shelf in 2020. Scientists watching its movements say the iceberg has followed nearly the same path as other large ice masses in the past.

The icebergs generally pass the east side of the Antarctic Peninsula through the Weddell Sea along a path known as "iceberg alley." They are pushed by the world's most powerful ocean current system, the Antarctic Circumpolar Current.

I'm Bryan Lynn.

Agence France-Presse reported on this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

iceberg - n. ภูเขาน้ำแข็งก้อนใหญ่ที่ลอยอยู่ในทะเลอย่างอิสระ

shelf - n. พื้นที่น้ำค่อนข้างตื้นที่ล้อมรอบแผ่นดิน

continental shelf - n. พื้นที่น้ำค่อนข้างตื้นที่ทอดยาวจากแผ่นดินใหญ่ของโลกและพ้นจากบริเวณนั้นจะเป็นมหาสมุทรลึก

obstacle - n. บางสิ่งที่ทำให้เป็นเรื่องยากหรือขวางทางในการทำบางสิ่ง; เครื่องกีดขวาง

divert - v. ส่งใครบางคนหรือบางสิ่งไปยังที่อื่นนอกเหนือจากที่พวกเขาคาดว่าจะไป

glacier - n. มวลน้ำแข็งขนาดใหญ่ที่เคลื่อนที่ช้ามาก โดยปกติจะไหลลงมาตามเนินเขาหรือหุบเขา

alley - n. ถนนแคบๆ หรือสถานที่ที่สิ่งต่างๆ มีแนวโน้มที่จะผ่านไป

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary concern of scientists regarding the large iceberg mentioned in the article?

A. It might melt too quickly in the South Atlantic Ocean.

- B. It could disrupt shipping lanes in the region.
- C. It poses a threat to wildlife on an island.
- D. It indicates an unusual change in ocean currents.

2. Which of the following statements accurately describes the iceberg's current status and destination?

- A. It is the smallest iceberg in the world, moving towards the Falkland Islands.
- B. It is the largest iceberg in the world, heading towards South Georgia.
- C. It is a British overseas territory, moving through the South Atlantic.
- D. It is moving away from the South Atlantic towards the Antarctic shelf.

3. What is the geographical relationship between South Georgia and the Falkland Islands?

- A. South Georgia is located approximately 1,400 kilometers west of the Falkland Islands.
- B. South Georgia is a British overseas territory situated about 1,400 kilometers east of the Falkland Islands.
- C. The Falkland Islands are a British overseas territory, west of South Georgia.
- D. Both islands are part of the same continental landmass.

4. What makes South Georgia particularly important for certain animal species?

- A. It serves as a primary source of fresh water for marine life.
- B. It is a main mating ground for wildlife, especially penguins and seals.
- C. It provides a unique migratory path for various bird species.
- D. It is a protected research facility for Antarctic animals.

5. What is the official name of the iceberg causing concern, and when did it originate?

- A. B23a, existing since 2020.
- B. A23a, formed in 1986.
- C. South Georgia Ice, broken off in 1986.
- D. Antarctic Shelf Ice, named in 2020.

6. What was the original source of Iceberg A23a?

- A. It formed directly in the South Atlantic Ocean.
- B. It broke off from the Falkland Islands.
- C. It originated from the Antarctic shelf.
- D. It was a fragment of another large iceberg.

7. How are scientists tracking the movements of Iceberg A23a?

- A. Using underwater sonar systems.
- B. By deploying manned research vessels.
- C. Through satellite imagery.
- D. With weather balloons and radar.

8. According to Andrew Meijers, what is an important observation about Iceberg A23a compared to other 'megabergs'?

- A. It has already begun to break into smaller pieces.
- B. It is moving much faster than anticipated.
- C. It has not broken into smaller pieces.
- D. It has changed direction unexpectedly.

9. What is one of Andrew Meijers' main concerns regarding the iceberg's interaction with South Georgia?

- A. The iceberg might collide with passing ships.
- B. The iceberg will completely miss the island and pose no threat.
- C. The iceberg will get caught on the underground continental shelf around South Georgia.
- D. The iceberg will cause a sudden rise in sea level near the island.

10. If the iceberg gets stuck on the continental shelf, what are the potential immediate consequences for the iceberg itself, according to Meijers?

- A. It will quickly melt away due to warmer waters.
- B. It could remain there for months or break into pieces.
- C. It will instantly alter the local ocean currents.
- D. It will form a permanent land bridge to the mainland.

11. What specific harm does Meijers associate with icebergs grounding near South Georgia, based on past experiences?

- A. It causes significant erosion of the island's coastline.
- B. It leads to the destruction of plant life on the island.
- C. It has led to the deaths of young penguins and seals.
- D. It introduces invasive species to the island's ecosystem.

12. What is Raul Cordero's prediction about Iceberg A23a's trajectory concerning South Georgia?

- A. He believes it will definitely hit South Georgia.
- B. He thinks it will miss South Georgia.
- C. He expects it to break apart before reaching the island.

D. He predicts it will cause a major tsunami.

13. According to Raul Cordero, what is the primary reason he believes the iceberg will miss South Georgia?

- A. The iceberg is too small to be significantly affected by ocean currents.
- B. South Georgia's strong magnetic field will repel the iceberg.
- C. The island acts as an obstacle for ocean currents, diverting the water that moves the iceberg.
- D. Historical data shows no icebergs have ever hit South Georgia.

14. What is Soledad Tiranti's general observation about large icebergs like A23a before they reach an island or mainland?

- A. They tend to speed up due to increased currents.
- B. They usually break apart into smaller, harmless pieces.
- C. They generally get stuck on the seabed because they are so deep.
- D. They completely melt away due to warmer temperatures.

15. Besides the iceberg, what other challenge have the seal and penguin populations on South Georgia been facing recently, according to Meijers?

- A. A severe shortage of their primary food sources.
- B. A 'bad season' with cases of bird flu.
- C. Unusually high numbers of predators.
- D. Excessive human interference in their habitat.